

August 23, 2023, India: There was no cricket match involving the Indian team that day. No new southern blockbuster had been released in theatres, nor was there a lockdown or curfew. Yet an hour before India's mission to the moon, Chandrayaan-3, was to land on the lunar surface,

over the years, Isro's ecosystem has included a diverse set of firms: From public sector undertakings to the legacy names of India Inc. and fledgling spacetechn start-ups. These firms have gained invaluable experience with each mission, and that in turn has bolstered their confidence to the extent that some are now looking to strike out on their own. In this changed scenario, marked by the watershed of Chandrayaan-3, there is a growing recognition of Indian firms' prowess and promise, reflected in the easier availability of funds. Another indicator of this change is the sudden spurt in the number of spacetechn start-ups to more than 150 entities, which is the highest in Asia. These firms are spread across the gamut of space activities, from launch services to small satellite constellations to space tourism. And they are vying for a share in the \$386-billion global private space industry, which is expected to grow to \$1 trillion by 2040.

EMERGING FROM ISRO'S SHADOW

"While the Chandrayaan series has been led by Isro, there has been significant participation by the private sector in supplying components. It goes to the agency's credit that it identified suppliers who have over time developed capabilities to support a high-end mission like the Chandrayaan series," Lt Gen. (Retd) Anil Kumar Bhatt, Director General of the apex industry body the Indian Space Association (ISpA), tells *Business Today*.

The list includes notable public sector enterprises such as Bharat Electronics Ltd, Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd, Electronics Corp. of India Ltd, Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd, Kerala State Electronics Develop-

people across the country either sat quietly glued to television screens or watched the event unfold on their smartphones. It broke all records on YouTube with 8 million concurrent views on the Indian Space Research Organisation's (Isro) channel. The Vikram lander successfully touched down near the moon's South Pole at 18:03 IST, and the nation erupted in joy.

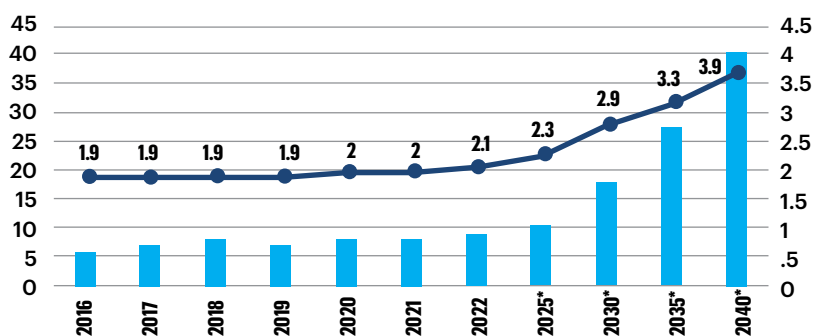
Not only had India become the fourth in the world to make a soft

landing on the lunar surface, it also became the first to successfully land near its South Pole. But beyond the euphoria, the event also signalled the triumph of more than 400 private companies that are part of the vendor ecosystem that Isro has nurtured since its founding in 1969 to service its components, materials, and fabrication requirements.

Indeed, each successful step that Isro has taken has turned into a giant leap for these firms. And

READY FOR TAKEOFF

● SIZE OF INDIA'S SPACE SECTOR (\$ BILLION) —● SHARE IN GLOBAL MARKET (RHS, IN %); *ESTIMATES; SOURCE MARKET RESEARCH, ARTHUR D. LITTLE



> The country's space sector could potentially be worth \$40 billion by 2040

> It is forecast to grow at a CAGR of 9 per cent to attain 4 per cent market share globally